

Ready to fly: Leon Mendonca's victory with a score of 9.5/13 in the Challengers section and his invitation to the prestigious 2025 Tata Steel Masters underscore the fearlessness of Indian competitors, undeterred by reputations. HARRY GIELEN

Mendonca books ticket to next Masters

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Rakesh Rao

rakesh.rao@thehindu.co.in

From the era of Viswanathan Anand challenging world chess giants to today's immensely gifted youngsters making waves against elite players, Indian chess is giving fans more reasons to rejoice than ever.

After the 2022 Chess Olympiad and the 2023 World Cup highlighted the growth of Indian chess, news of five Indians qualifying for the 2024 Candidates tournaments solidified India as a new force.

If the twin triumphs of Vidit Gujrathi and R. Vaishali in the premier Grand Swiss event last year underlined the increasing chess strength of India, the consistency of D. Gukesh, Vidit, and an unbeaten R. Praggnanandhaa in the Tata Steel Masters in Wijk aan Zee, the Netherlands, was another fine advertisement for Indian chess.

Leon Mendonca's (9.5/13) win in the Challengers section and his invite to the esteemed 2025 Tata Steel Masters highlight Indians as bold competitors unswayed by reputations.

Gukesh continues to thrill. He

overcame an ordinary start to display his class and tied for the Masters title with eventual champions Wei Yi, Anish Giri, and Nodirbek Abdusattorov at 8.5 points from 13 rounds in the 14-player field.

Until 2018, those tied for titles were considered joint champions. Since then, tie-break games have been introduced to ascertain the winner.

For instance, five-time winner Anand won twice and tied thrice between 1989 and 2006. For the record, eight-time winner Magnus Carlsen's only shared title was also his first in 2008, with Armenian Levon